

“The men and teams **suffered severely** with the **intense heat** and want of water.”

UNION MAJOR ISAAC LYNDE, REPORT ON THE SURRENDER AT SAN AUGUSTIN SPRINGS, AUGUST 7, 1861

The Confederate push west

Brigadier General Henry H. Sibley had devised an ambitious plan to use Confederate Arizona as a launch pad for a drive into the gold- and silver-rich states of Colorado and California. With three regiments of cavalry from Texas, he advanced up the Rio Grande River as far as Fort Craig, absorbing most of Baylor's troops along the way. The fort, a Union stronghold, was under the command of Colonel Edward Canby, whose regulars were supported by New Mexican volunteers. Sibley's force was too weak to seize the fort and tried to bypass it, but Canby marched out to block his path at a ford near Valverde. The two forces joined battle on February 21. In the end, Canby and his men had to retreat back into the fort. Sibley continued to push northward, reaching Santa Fe on March 10.

Ahead of Sibley, Union forces from Colorado under Colonel John Slough joined a Northern garrison at Fort Union. The campaign's crucial battle occurred at Glorieta Pass in the Sangre de Cristo Mountains. On March 26, forward units of Northern soldiers pushing south from Fort Union met the foremost contingent of Confederate cavalry advancing north from Santa Fe. After an initial skirmish, both sides moved up reinforcements and were ready to fight on March 28. Both moved to attack because each assumed the other would stand on the defensive. Despite suffering as many casualties as their enemies, the Confederates held the field after a fierce engagement. But a Union detachment dispatched to carry out a flanking attack found itself behind the Confederates, surprising